

HACK THE BOX SHERLOCK - THREAT INTELLIGENCE

AOTR 2: OPERATION WINTER BLACKOUT

Sherlock Scenario

[Advent of The Relics 2 - Operation Winter Blackout](#)

Read the campaign introduction and supporting information at

<https://github.com/hackthebox/advent-of-the-relics>

A phishing attack on a logistics company has led investigators to a [private criminal forum](#). The crew behind it has been planning something big for months. Your job is to dig through their communications and uncover who they are, what they're targeting, and how they plan to disappear.

The forum can be accessed at: <https://advent-of-the-relics-forum.htb.blue>

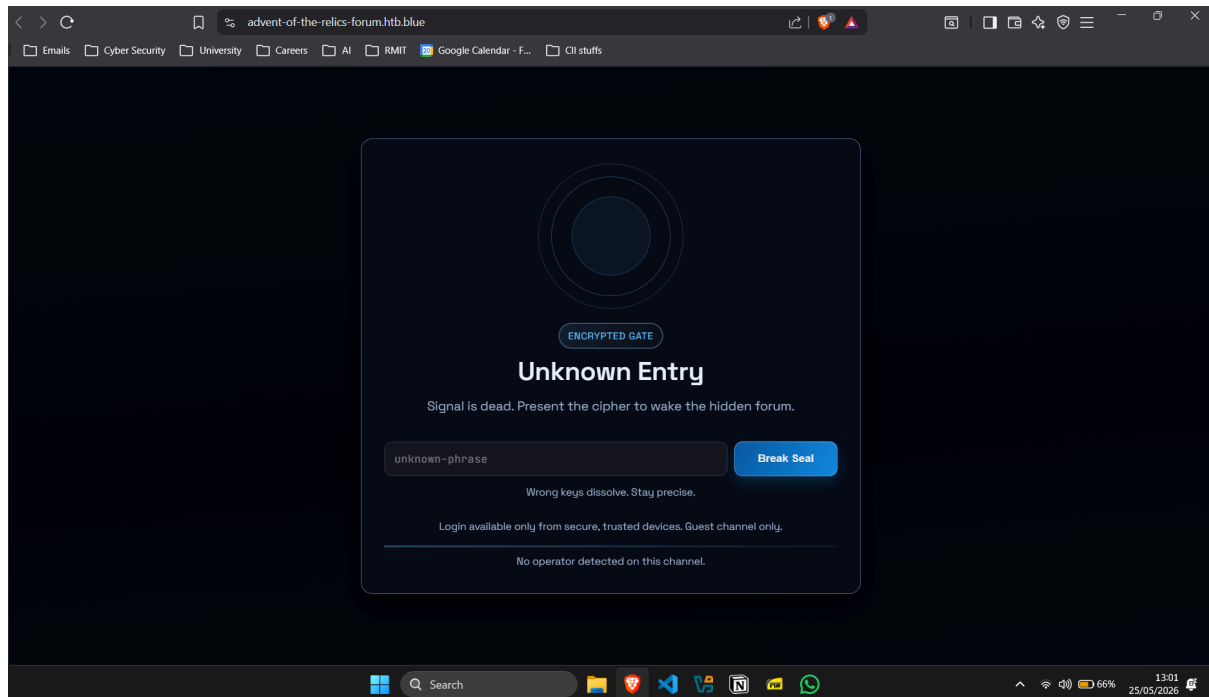
First, you will need to gain access to the forum using the password

[SnowBlackOut_2026!](#), which you found in your [previous investigation](#), to unlock the intel inside.

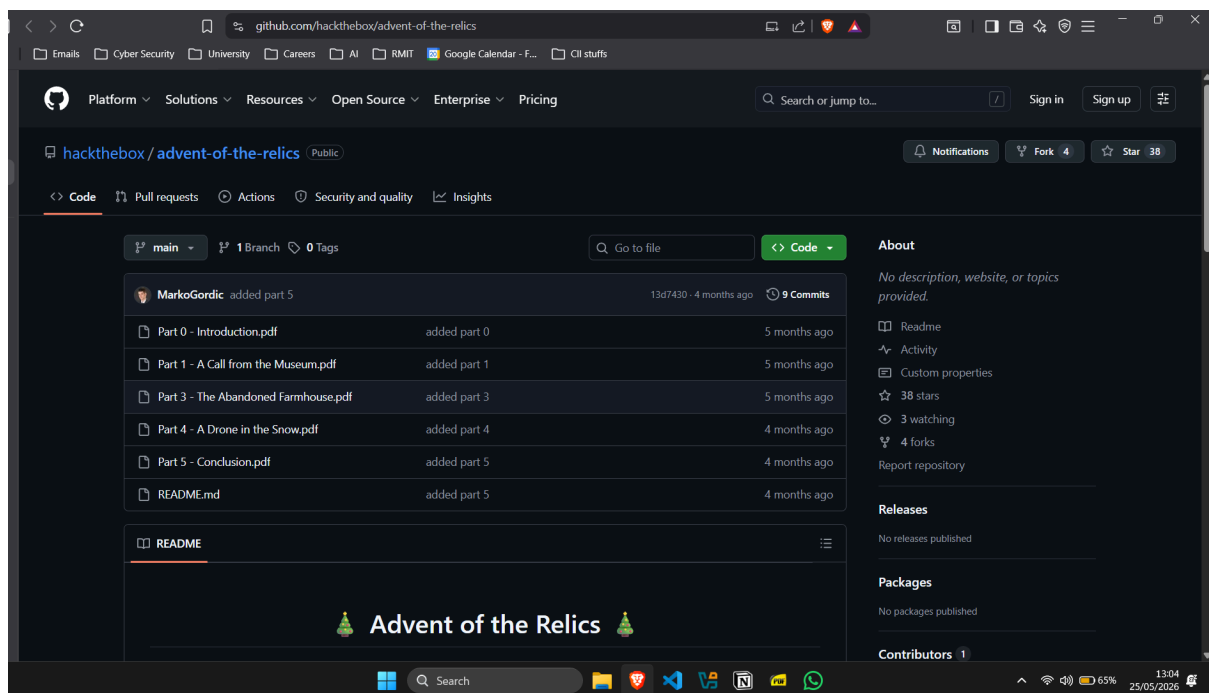
The scenario portrayed in this challenge is entirely fictional and created solely for educational and entertainment purposes. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, organizations, or real events is purely coincidental and unintentional. All characters, scenarios, and data presented are products of imagination.

For this Sherlock, there are no provided files to be downloaded, so all is from the Internet.

Rafael Angelo Christianto



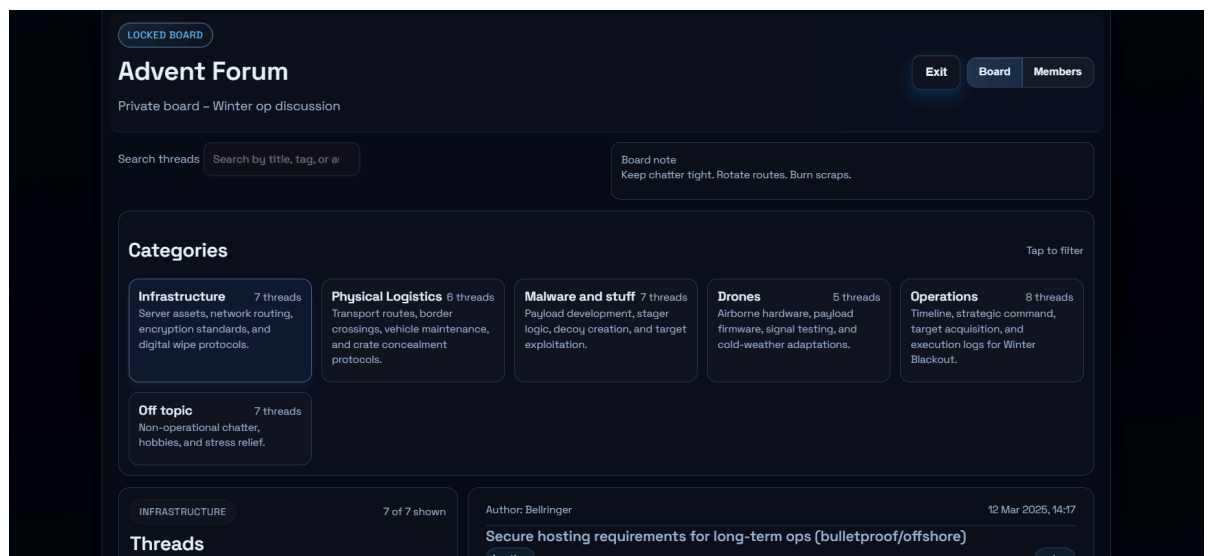
We are provided with the link: <https://advent-of-the-relics-forum.htb.blue/>. The screenshot of the page is given above. And the unknown phrase is given by the Sherlock which is SnowBlackOut_2026!.



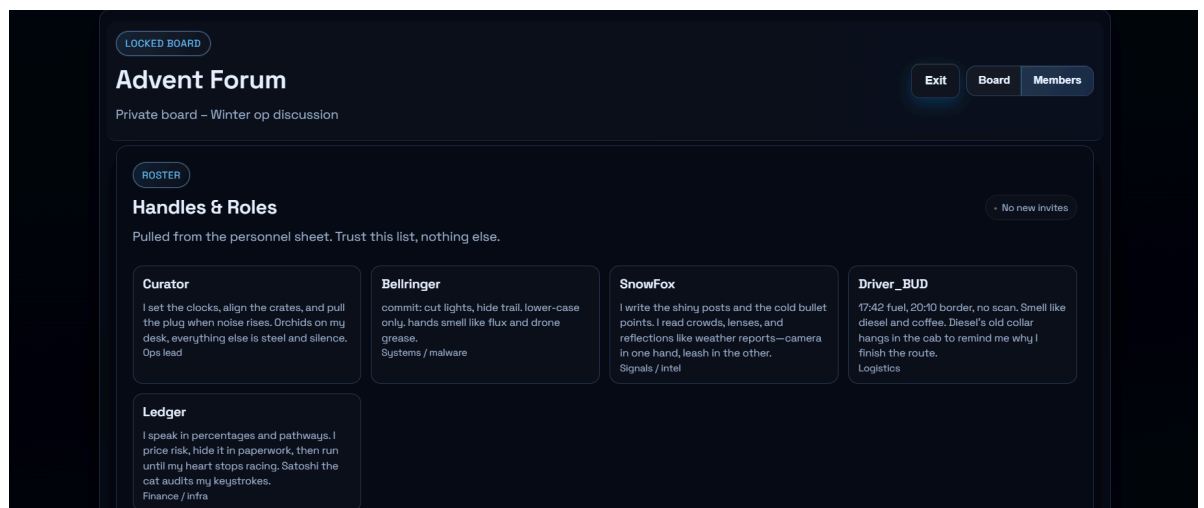
And also the Sherlock gave a GitHub repository at this link:

<https://github.com/hackthebox/advent-of-the-relics>

1. How many suspects are using this forum?



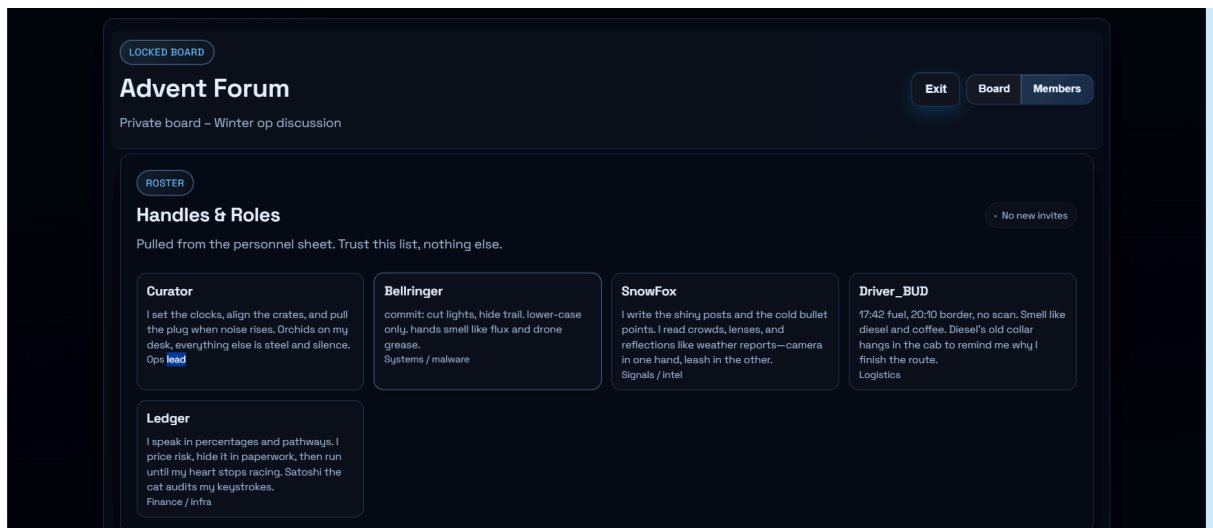
After using the unknown phrase at the website, it leads to this website, where we can see each category's description of chats, of what do they contain.



Switching it over to the Members tab, we can see **5** members of the forum who are:

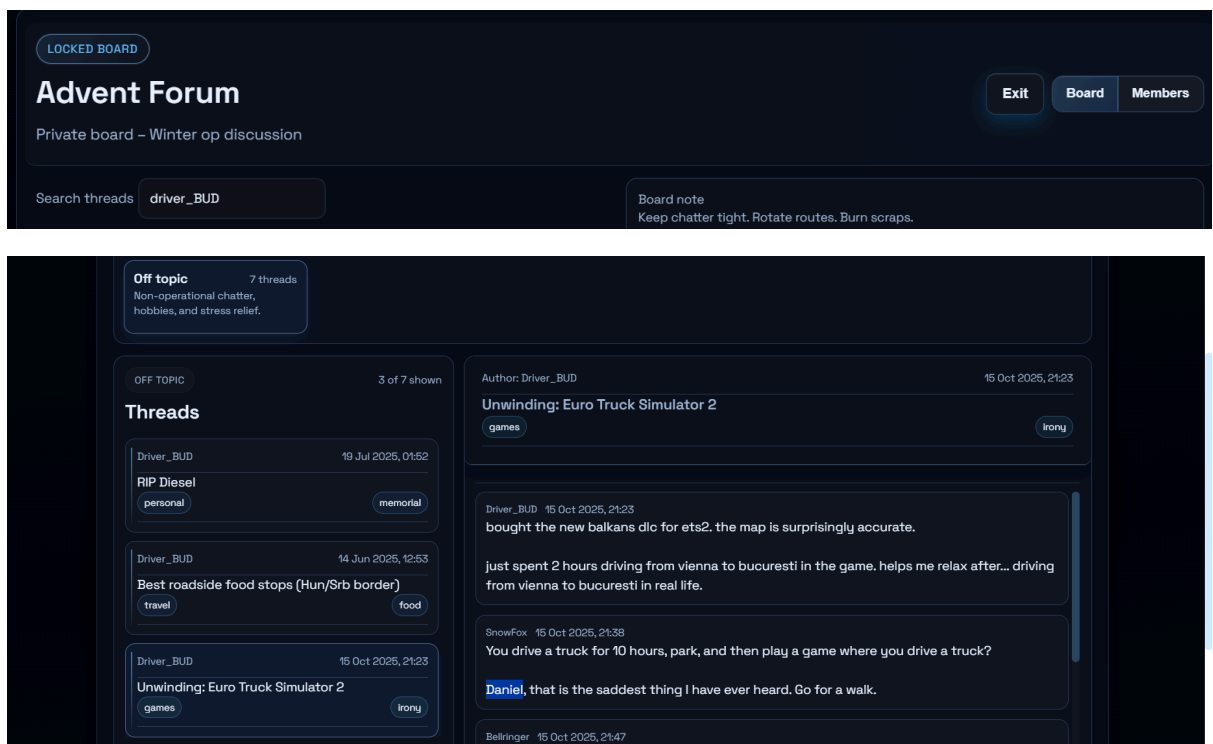
- Curator
- Bellringer
- SnowFox
- Driver_BUD
- Ledger

2. What is the username of the group's leader?



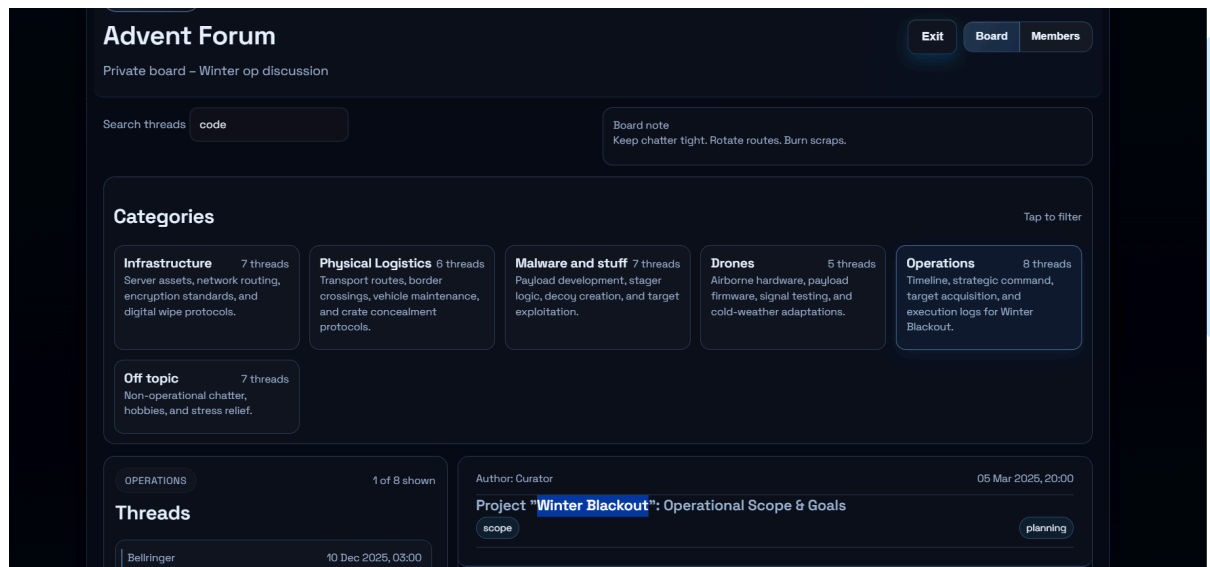
Here I search the lead, and here I found **Curator** to be the Ops lead.

3. What is Driver_BUD's real first name?



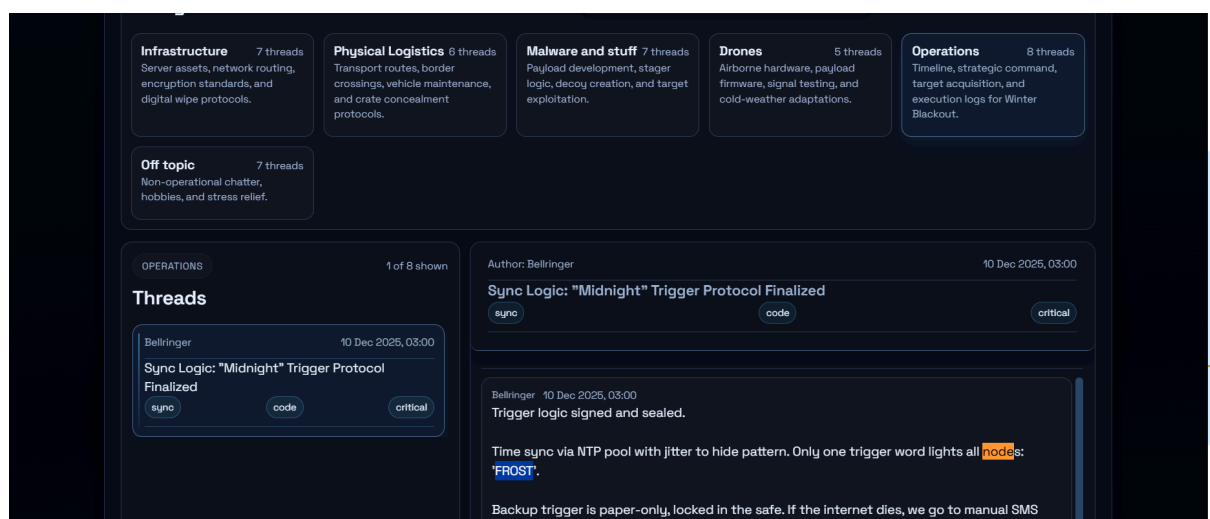
Here I searched in the Search threads field "driver_BUD" and here in the Off topic category I found SnowFox calling Driver_BUD **Daniel** which is his real first name as highlighted in the screenshot above.

4. What is the codename of the operation?



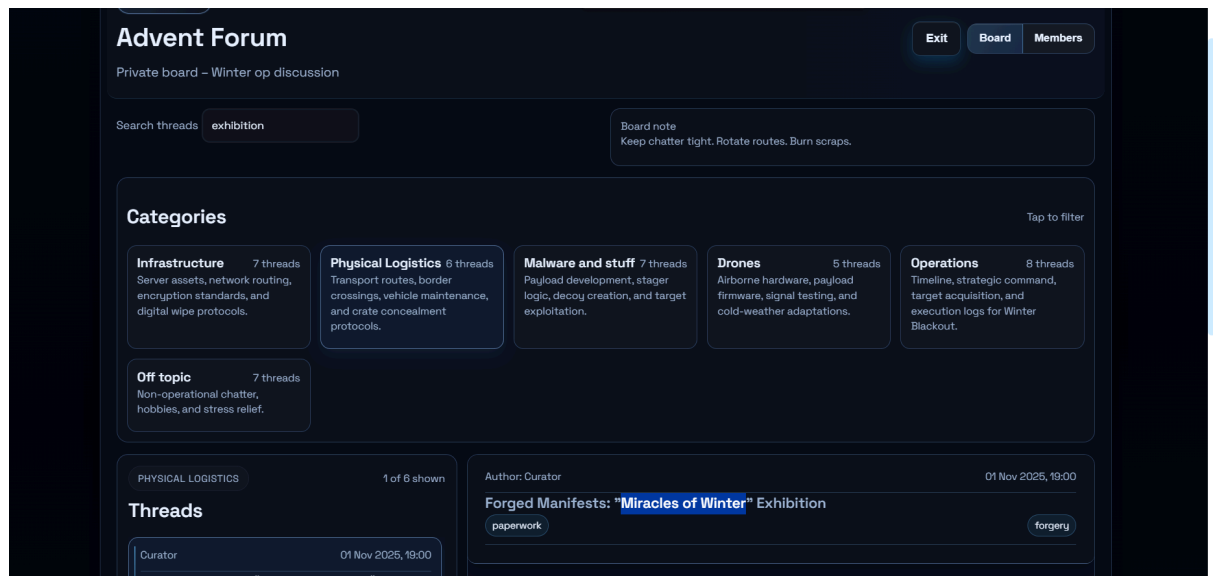
Still in the Advent Forum I searched up “code” in the Operations category and found it to be **Winter Blackout**

5. What single word is the trigger code that activates all nodes?



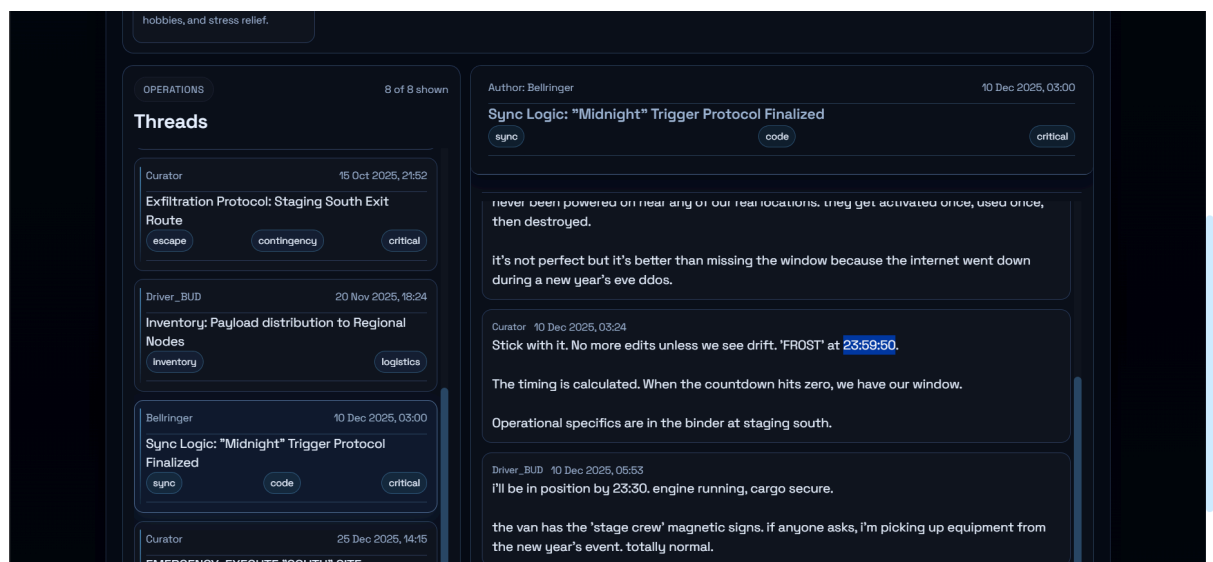
Here still under the Operations thread I searched up the “node” string and found the trigger to be **FROST**

6. What is the name of the fake exhibition used as cover for the heist?



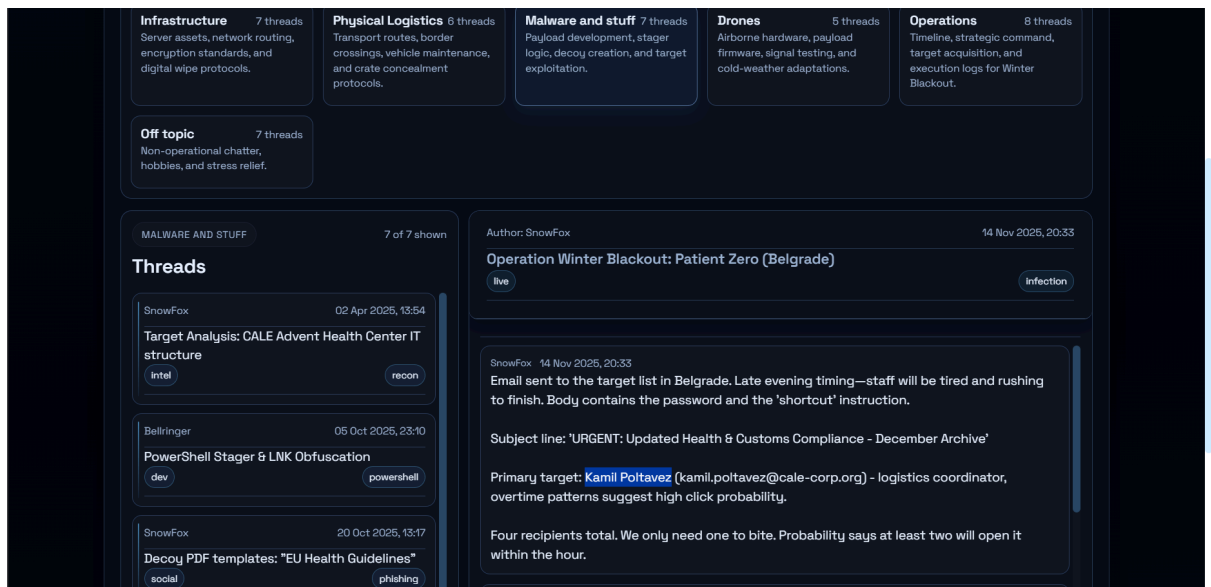
Here under the Advent Forum, I searched up “exhibition” on the Search threads field, and under the Physical Logistics category I found a forged and fake exhibition called **Miracles of Winter**

7. What time was the single word trigger scheduled to execute on New Year's Eve?

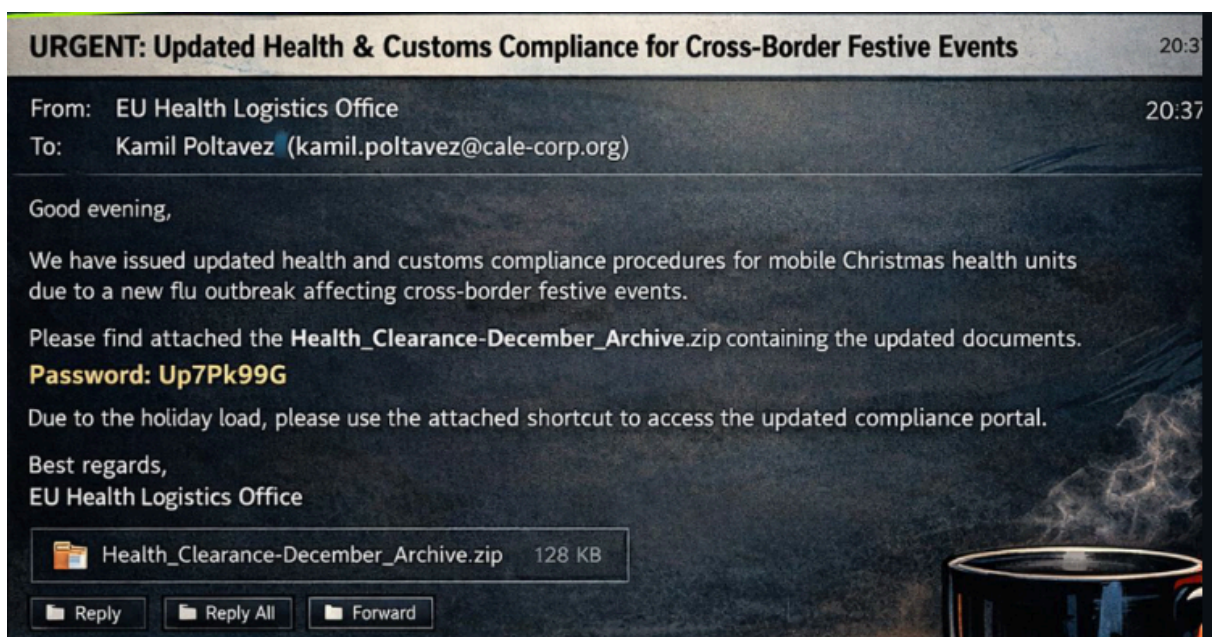


Here we see under the Operations category, at the Midnight Trigger Protocol chat, that the word trigger “FROST” is going to execute at **23:59:50**

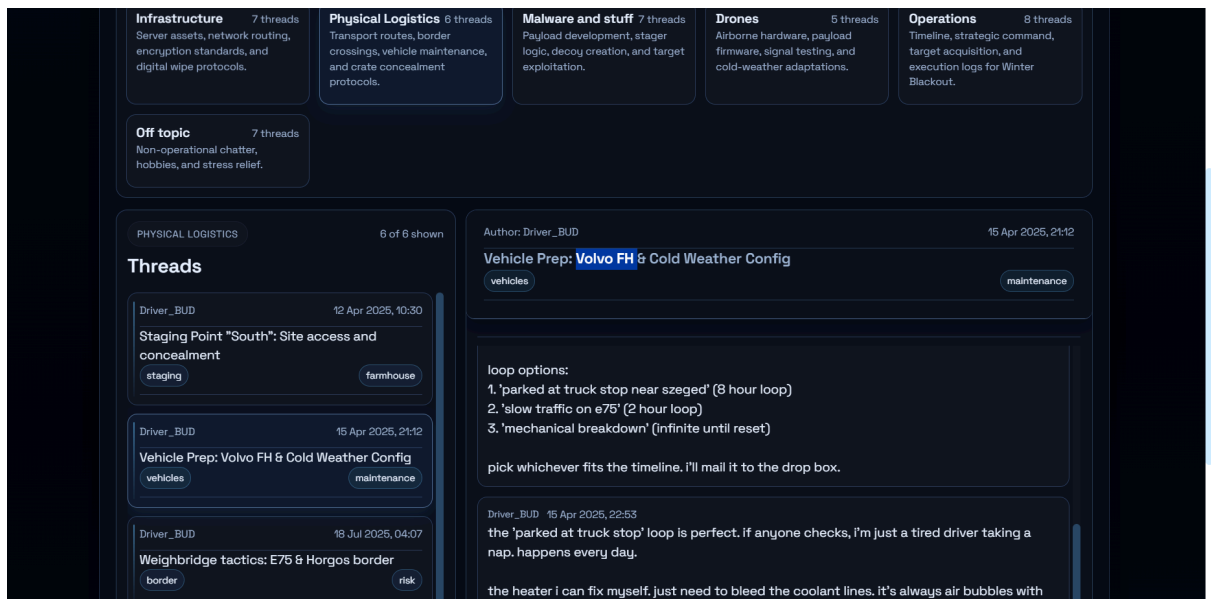
8. What is the full name of the phishing target at CALE?



The primary target for the phishing campaign at CALE is found under the Malware and stuff category as it is said as the Primary Target is **Kamil Poltavez**. The email is shown below:

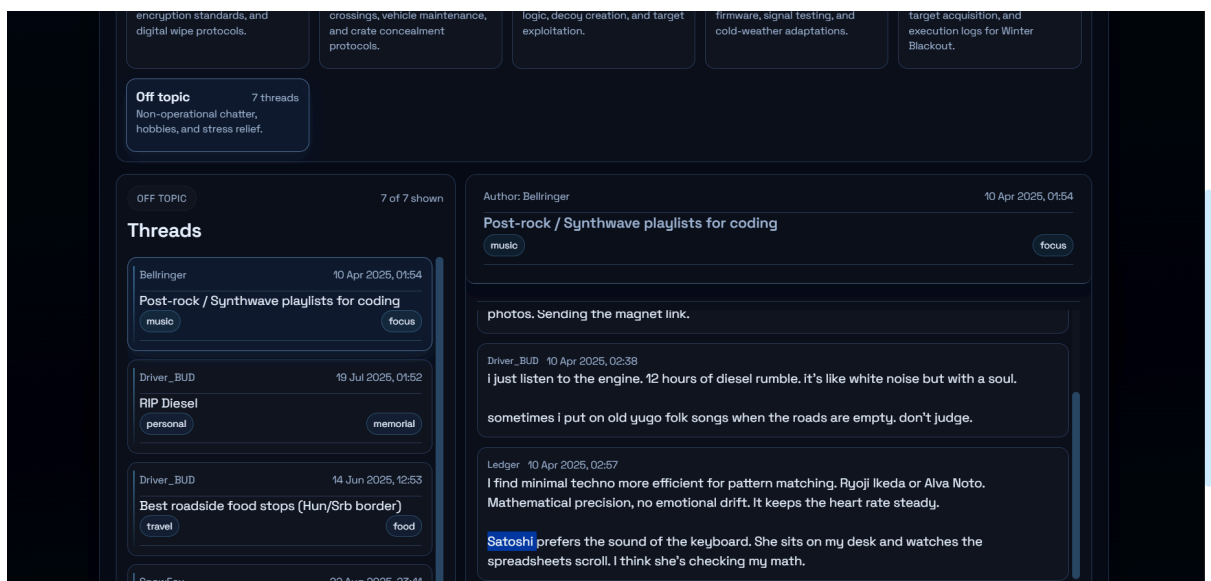


9. What make and model is the truck used for transport?



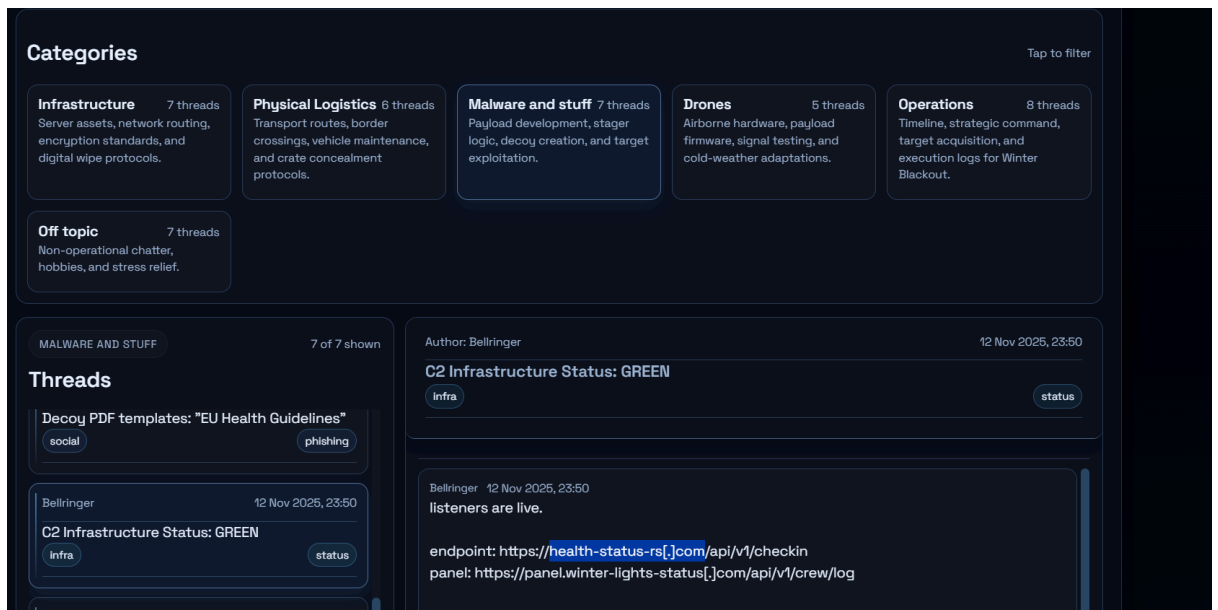
Here in the Physical Logistics category forum we can see the truck make and model which is a **Volvo FH**

10.What is the name of Ledgers cat?



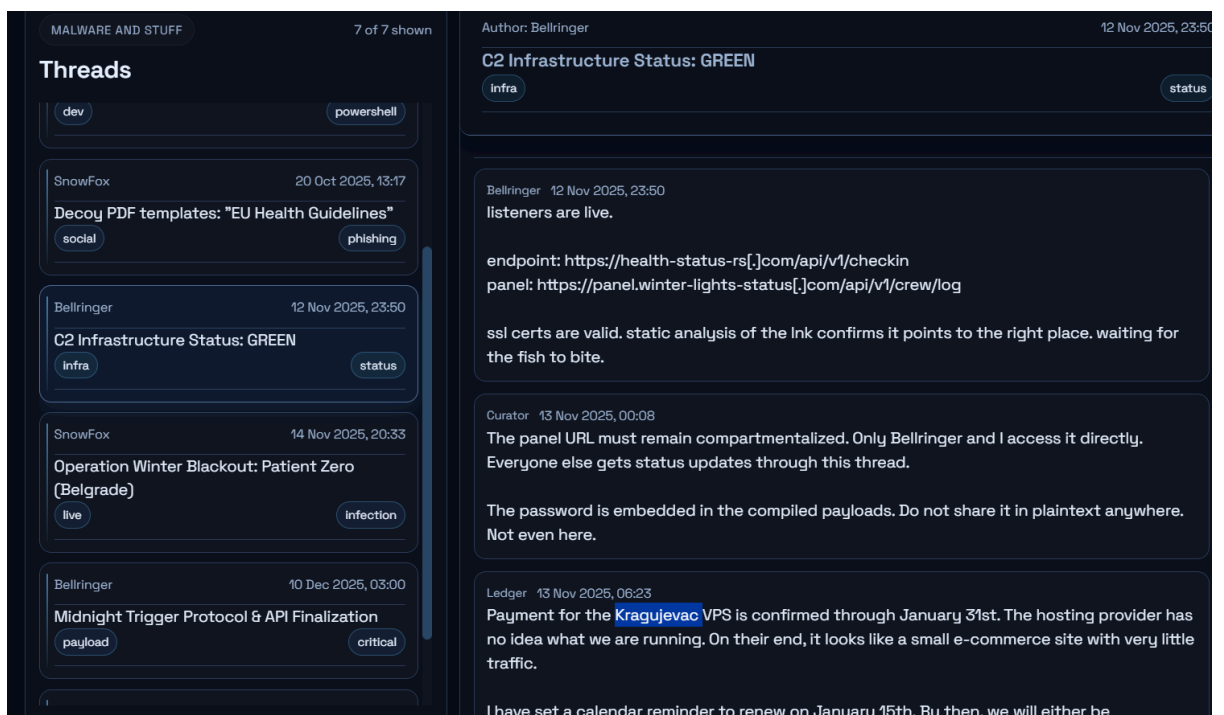
Here at the Off topic category, since it is not related to the attack, **Satoshi** is mentioned to sit on Ledger's desk so it is his cat's name

11.What is the primary C2 domain used for beacon check-ins?



Here in the Malware and stuff category and the C2 thread we see an endpoint called [https://health-status-rs\[.\]com/api/v1/checkin](https://health-status-rs[.]com/api/v1/checkin), which would be the primary C2 domain so the answer to this question is **health-status-rs.com**

12. In which city is the VPS server hosting the C2 panel?



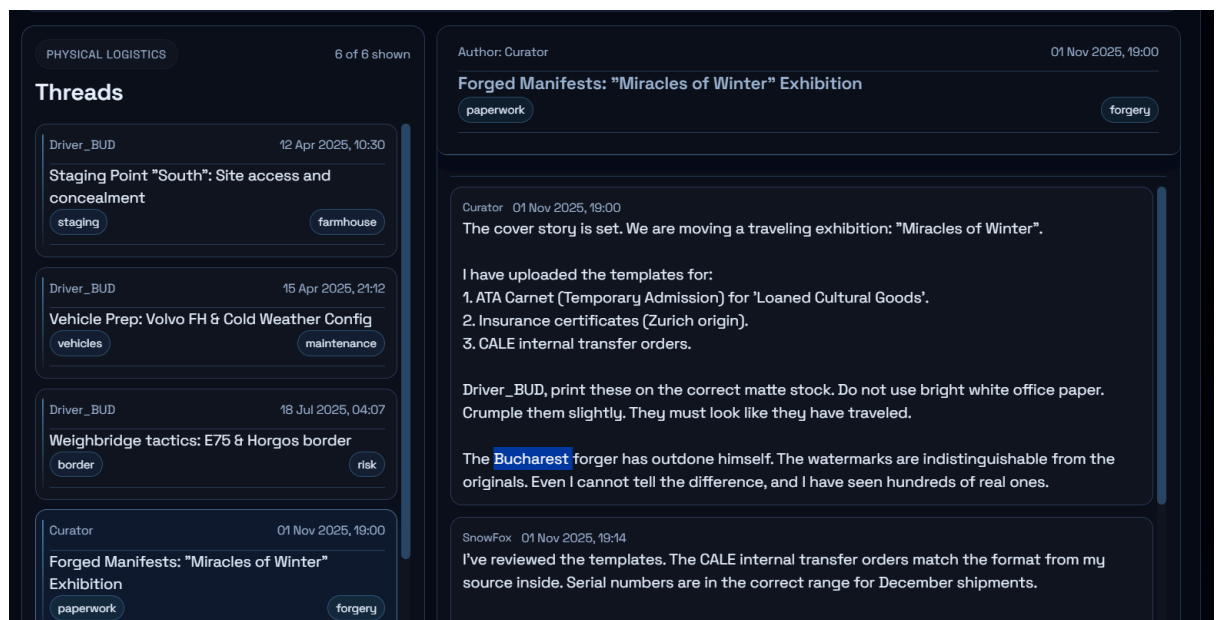
Here we can see in the same thread that the VPS is located in **Kragujevac**, the fourth largest city in Serbia.

13. On what date did the C2 listeners go live?



Still at the same thread as the previous question I need to get the date when the C2 server is live and following the format of the question, the answer is **2025-11-12**

14. In which city is the document forger located?



Here we see in the forged manifest thread for the fake exhibition there that the **Bucharest** that he forged the documents and talked that the watermarks are indistinguishable.

15. What shell company was used as a backup cover story?

The screenshot displays a digital interface with a sidebar on the left and a main content area on the right. The sidebar is titled 'OPERATIONS' and shows a list of threads. The main content area displays a thread titled 'Contingency Protocols: If "Carnet" access is revoked' under the 'contingency' category. The thread includes a ledger entry from 'Curator' dated 10 Oct 2025, 09:41, which mentions 'Danube Event Solutions Ltd' and a shell company with a website and Google Business listing. Other entries include a 'Dry Run: Local Grid Interference Test (Sector 4)' and an 'Exfiltration Protocol: Staging South Exit Route'.

Here at the Operations category under the Contingency Protocols thread there is an invoice from **Danube Event Solutions Ltd** which says to have a fully functioning website and a Google Business listing.

16. What is the filename of the wipe script used to destroy evidence?

The screenshot displays a digital interface with a sidebar on the left and a main content area on the right. The sidebar is titled 'INFRASTRUCTURE' and shows a list of threads. The main content area displays a thread titled 'Server Wipe Protocols' under the 'failsafe' category. The thread includes a ledger entry from 'Curator' dated 01 Dec 2025, 08:00, which mentions a single-command termination protocol. Another entry from 'Bellringer' dated 01 Dec 2025, 08:34, mentions a script named 'burn_cycle.sh' deployed to root on all nodes. A third entry from 'Bellringer' dated 25 Dec 2025, 12:15, mentions a function that overwrites cryptographic headers and fills RAM with random noise.

In the Infrastructure category there is a Thread called Server Wipe Protocols called **burn_cycle.sh** and it is used to wipe and destroy the evidence, it does 3 functions which are:

- overwrites cryptographic headers (luksDump --wipe).
- fills the RAM with random noise.

- triggers kernel panic and hard shutdown.

17. What is the name of the escape vessel?

The screenshot shows a forum interface with a sidebar on the left and a main content area on the right. The sidebar, under the heading 'Threads', lists several threads. The main content area displays a thread titled 'Exfiltration Protocol: Staging South Exit Route' by 'Author: Curator' on '15 Oct 2025, 21:52'. The thread has three tags: 'escape', 'contingency', and 'critical'. The content of the thread includes a meeting point in Athens, a phrase to memorize ('twitchy develop hulk'), GPS coordinates, and the name of a vessel, 'Adriatic Wind', which is highlighted in blue. The thread also mentions a payment of €800 and a meeting with someone named Stavros.

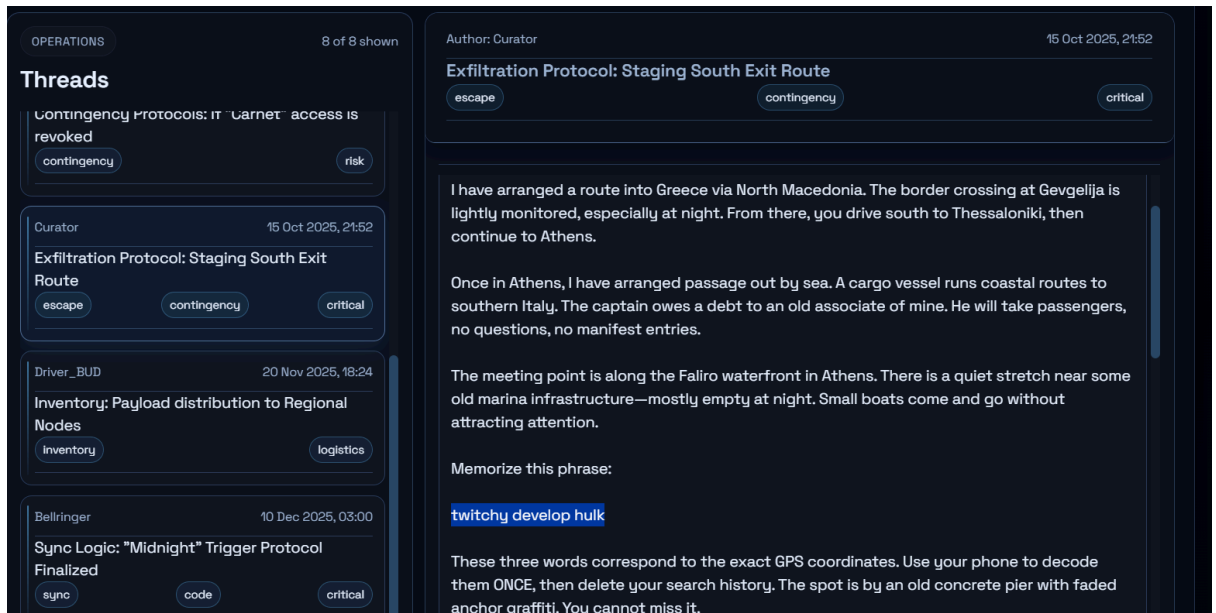
Here in the Operations category and the Exfiltration Protocol: Staging South Exit Route thread and there is an escape vessel at January 3 that arrives at 04:00 called **Adriatic Wind**.

18. What is the captain's name?

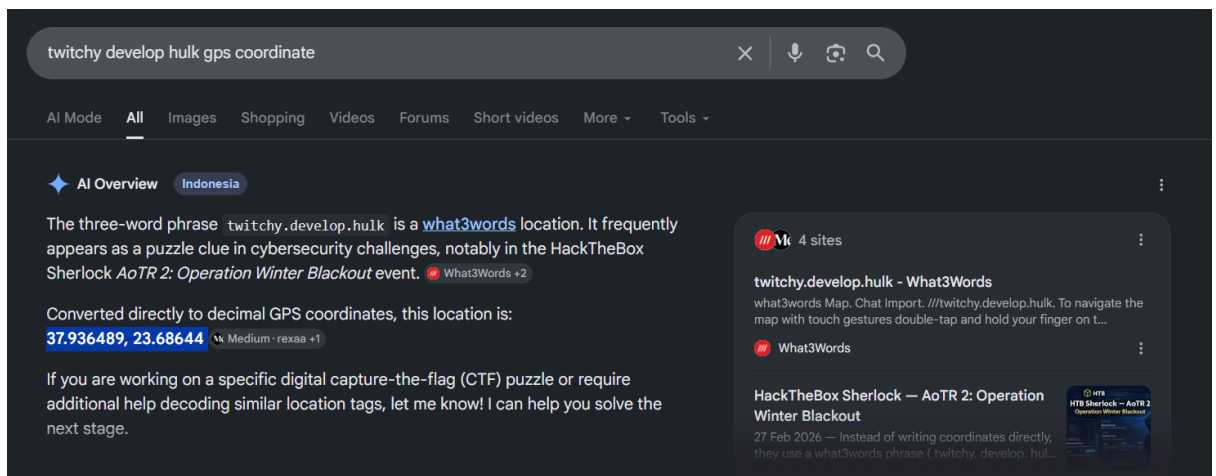
This screenshot shows the same forum thread as the previous one, but with the text 'Ask for Stavros' highlighted in blue. The name 'Stavros' is the captain's name mentioned in the thread.

Still in the same category and thread the captain's name is **Stavros** who will be paid €800 and will help clear Greek waters.

19. What are the GPS coordinates of the emergency extraction point for Driver_BUD?



Here on the Operations category still under the same thread there is a phrase "twitchy develop hulk" which corresponds to the exact GPS coordinates and can be decoded.



After decoding the string we can see the GPS coordinates which is **37.936489, 23.68644**

20. What are the GPS coordinates of the farmhouse hideout?

PHYSICAL LOGISTICS 6 of 6 shown

Threads

Driver_BUD 12 Apr 2025, 10:30

Staging Point "South": Site access and concealment

staging farmhouse

Driver_BUD 15 Apr 2025, 21:12

Vehicle Prep: Volvo FH 8 Cold Weather Config

vehicles maintenance

Driver_BUD 18 Jul 2025, 04:07

Weighbridge tactics: E75 & Horgos border

Author: Driver_BUD 12 Apr 2025, 10:30

Staging Point "South": Site access and concealment

staging farmhouse

Driver_BUD 12 Apr 2025, 10:30

secured the keys to the property. it's a wreck. roof leaks in the barn, windows are blacked out. perfect for us.

gps coords for your nav: **43.84947615369828, 20.92715775614975**

road is barely a track. if it snows hard, i can't get the big rig all the way to the door. will need to shuttle crates with the van from the main road (2km out).

neighbors are few. one old guy 500m east. i told him i bought the place to store firewood.

Here under the Physical Logistics category there is another coordinate that is the category for the farmhouse seeing it having a barn and windows are blacked out making it a good farmhouse. The coordinates are **43.84947615369828, 20.92715775614975**



You have solved AoTR 2: Operation Winter Blackout!

Congratulations  **rafaelangelo** best of luck in capturing flags ahead!

#714	25 May 2026	Active
Sherlock Rank	Solve Date	Sherlock State

Ok Share